

Cues of Commitment: Integration and Naturalization Support in Taiwan and South Korea

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Abstract

Does immigrant civic engagement increase public support for naturalization outside Western democracies? We examine that question with conjoint experiments embedded in a structured comparison of South Korea and Taiwan ($N=4,049$), two recently immigrant-receiving democracies whose post-democratization trajectories diverged in ways that bear directly on immigrant incorporation. South Korea combines dense migrant advocacy networks with more ascriptive membership boundaries, whereas Taiwan combines weaker migrant advocacy with a more civic-territorial identity regime. The comparison lets us weigh civic legacy and identity regime accounts against each other. Integration cues increase support for naturalization in both countries, but the effects are consistently larger in Taiwan. They also soften identity-based penalties. In Taiwan, volunteering and community participation sharply reduce penalties faced by Muslim and non-co-ethnic applicants. In South Korea, those penalties persist, especially for Muslim applicants. On balance, the pattern fits the identity regime account better than the civic legacy account.

Keywords: immigration, citizenship, public opinion, experiments, East Asia

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1 Introduction

When do acts of civic engagement persuade citizens that immigrants deserve to become citizens? Research in Western democracies shows that behavioral signals of commitment, such as volunteering and community participation, increase public support for immigrant inclusion (Levy and Wright, 2020; Weiss and Tulin, 2021; Sniderman, Hagendoorn and Prior, 2004). But this evidence comes from settings where civic participation is already widely recognized as a marker of good citizenship. Whether such behaviors carry the same weight in democracies with stronger ascriptive conceptions of nationhood is an open question.

Citizenship decisions define who belongs to the political community, the boundary of the political “we.” As diversity increases (De Haas, Castles and Miller, 2020) and identity conflicts sharpen (Norris and Inglehart, 2019), naturalization has become one place where those boundary disputes are fought. Scholarship on immigration attitudes is extensive (e.g., Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Dancygier and Laitin, 2014; Kustov, 2025), but public support for granting citizenship itself remains understudied (Peters, Vink and Schmeets, 2018), especially outside Western democracies.

South Korea and Taiwan form a useful comparison. Both democratized in the late 1980s and only recently became significant immigrant-receiving societies, but they diverged sharply in two domains that shape how publics interpret immigrant behavior: the national identity regime that defines who can belong, and the civil society institutions that frame immigrant incorporation.

In South Korea, labor, church, and human rights movements that fought for democratization later redirected their organizational capacity toward migrant advocacy, building durable partnerships with the state that now anchor a coordinated incorporation regime (Chung, 2020, 68–75). But that institutional architecture still sits inside an ethno-nationalist framework that democratization did little to dislodge. Korean ancestry remains central to popular definitions of nationhood (Shin, 2006; Hur, 2022; Jo, 2025), and minority identities face strong pressures to conform to dominant national frames (Denney, Steinhardt and Bhowmick, 2026).

Taiwan moved in the opposite direction. Democratization triggered a civic-territorial redefinition of national identity, as political allegiance, democratic values, and a pluralistic understanding of “Taiwanese-

ness” gradually displaced ethnic Han nationalism (Chu and Lin, 2001; Zhong, 2016). Ethnicity’s centrality weakened as competing parties claimed ownership of Taiwanese identity and non-Han histories entered public narratives (Wang and Liu, 2004; Simon, 2007; Chen, Lin and Yang, 2023). The resulting identity regime is more pluralistic and leaves room for a wider range of acceptable identities to coexist (Denney, Steinhardt and Bhowmick, 2026). Yet the civil society organizations involved in immigrant incorporation remain thin: fragmented, locally based, and weakly connected to state policy (Chung, 2020, 103–116).

These divergent trajectories generate two competing expectations. One, drawn from research on civic legacies, holds that historically rooted civil society networks heighten the public salience of civic participation. Organizations that emerged from democratization-era struggles can carry forward norms and practices that make acts of community engagement easier to recognize as evidence of commitment (Bloemraad, 2006; Marrow, 2005; Jones-Correa, 1998; de Graauw, 2016; Chung, 2020). If that account is right, South Korea’s stronger advocacy networks should make behavioral cues more influential there.

The alternative, drawn from work on national identity regimes, predicts that behavioral signals carry greater weight where the boundaries of membership are defined in civic-territorial rather than ascriptive terms (Brubaker, 1992; Shulman, 2004; Kunovich, 2009; Verkuyten and Martinovic, 2015). Where belonging rests on shared values and civic participation rather than ancestry, acts of community engagement map more directly onto widely held criteria for inclusion. If that account is right, Taiwan’s more pluralistic identity regime should make civic engagement a more persuasive basis for naturalization support.

The two mechanisms operate through distinct channels. Civic legacies work through the density of organizational networks that normalize pro-integration norms. National identity regimes work through the criteria that define who belongs, and specifically whether behavioral commitment can substitute for ascriptive markers like ancestry. Because South Korea scores high on the former and Taiwan on the latter, the two frameworks generate opposing expectations about where integration cues should exert the strongest effects.

We test these competing expectations using nationally representative conjoint survey experiments

fielded in South Korea and Taiwan in 2024 (N=4,049). Respondents evaluated randomly generated immigrant profiles that varied on twelve attributes, including ethnicity, religion, occupation, and behavioral integration cues: whether the immigrant volunteers at a local community center, co-hosts multicultural events, or engages in no visible civic activity. We use “integration cues” to refer to these behavioral signals because they capture an immigrant’s active participation in host-society civic life, the form of commitment most directly relevant to decisions about political membership. The design isolates the marginal effect of these behavioral signals on support for naturalization. We also embedded a brief framing prime highlighting civil society involvement in immigration policy to see whether activating civil society discourse alters cue responsiveness.

In both countries, integration cues raise support for naturalization, but not by the same amount. Respondents in Taiwan react more strongly than respondents in South Korea. The cues also do different work at the boundary of membership. In Taiwan, they shrink penalties for ethnically or culturally distant immigrants much more sharply. In South Korea, especially for Muslim applicants, sizable penalties remain. Civic behavior can soften exclusionary judgments in both places, but how much it does so depends on national context. The pattern fits the identity regime account better, though it does not settle the question.

The findings show that the meaning of integration cues depends on how national membership is defined. Civic behavior increases support for naturalization in both settings, but it matters more where national identity is defined in civic-territorial terms. In South Korea, where the boundaries of belonging remain more rigid and tied to ancestry, behavioral signals shift attitudes but do not fully offset cultural distance penalties. In Taiwan, where national identity has undergone a civic redefinition, integration cues match widely held membership criteria and produce stronger, more inclusive effects.

The paper contributes to comparative political behavior by showing how democratic publics turn behavioral evidence into judgments about full political membership, and by identifying the contexts in which those signals carry more weight.

2 The Politics of Immigration and Naturalization

Immigration and citizenship policy debates are becoming increasingly salient in societies that, until recently, had very small migrant populations and understood national belonging in largely ancestry-based terms. South Korea and Taiwan exemplify this shift. Within a generation, both moved from near-zero immigration to becoming significant immigrant-receiving societies relative to regional peers (see Figure 1). In Taiwan, the foreign-born share nearly doubled from 2.5 percent in 2010 to 4.9 percent in 2024, making it the most demographically diverse society in East Asia. In South Korea, the share grew from 1.2 percent to 3.5 percent over the same period. These demographic changes make it possible to examine how publics interpret immigrant incorporation in settings moving from low to moderate diversity.

Prior work on support for immigrant integration focuses predominantly on the United States and assumes that commitment cues reflect a distinct American civic nationalist tradition (Levy and Wright, 2020). Recent studies, however, challenge the assumption that shared civic values are unique to the American context, showing that values also shape immigrant integration in European settings (see Krakowski et al., 2025, for a review).

Because Western European countries and settler societies share long histories of large-scale immigration and more liberal individualist traditions, they are usually treated as the natural comparison set. We look instead at contexts where commitment cues should, if anything, have a harder time moving opinion, given strong legacies of ethnic nationalism and limited migration experience. That makes South Korea and Taiwan a useful place to ask how context shapes the effect of the same underlying mechanism, in line with Falsetti and Lynch's (2009) argument that mechanisms do not operate apart from context.

We focus on East Asian democracies with smaller immigrant populations to assess whether commitment cues depend on the normalization of immigration and broader acceptance of civic conceptions of national identity, or whether they operate more independently. In doing so, our comparative framework brings together three literatures: (1) individual-level determinants of immigration attitudes, including framing and behavioral signaling; (2) public support for immigrant naturalization, a distinct and politically important stage of incorporation; and (3) the macro-level role of civic legacies and national identity regimes in shaping how such cues are interpreted. Whereas most research focuses on attitudes toward

admission or residency (e.g., Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016), we examine the less studied yet normatively central question of who should be granted citizenship.

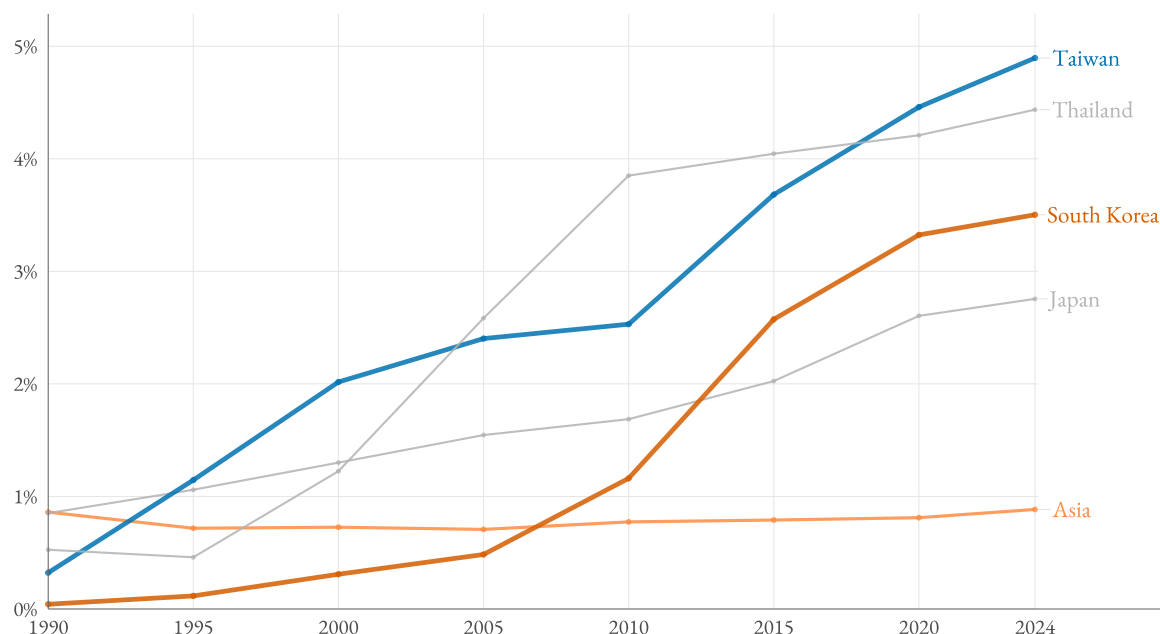


Figure 1: Share of the population that was born in another country. Data from the United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (2024), shown for selected regional comparators and the average for all of Asia.

2.1 Integration Cues as Signals of Norm Conformity

A large literature identifies economic interests (Scheve and Slaughter, 2001; Mayda, 2006), sociotropic concerns about national-level outcomes (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015), and symbolic or cultural threats (Kinder and Sears, 1981; Citrin, Reingold and Green, 1990; Sides and Citrin, 2007) as drivers of immigration attitudes (for a recent meta-analysis, see Weber et al., 2025). Economic self-interest plays a limited role (Hainmueller and Hiscox, 2010), whereas concerns about cultural fit, cohesion, and shared values exert substantial influence (Sniderman, Hagendoorn and Prior, 2004; Hooghe and Marks, 2018; Pehrson, Brown and Zagefka, 2009).

Within this broader tradition, what we call “integration cues” specify a behavioral mechanism through which immigrants may influence public support. These are observable acts of civic engagement

(volunteering, participation in community organizations, engagement with local institutions) that signal willingness to conform to shared norms and contribute to the polity (Baert and Vujić, 2016; Levy and Wright, 2020). We use the term “integration cues” rather than “civic engagement” because the mechanism operates through signaling: what matters is not participation per se but the information it conveys about an immigrant’s commitment to the host society. Experimental evidence from Western Europe and North America shows that such behavioral cues reliably increase support for immigrant inclusion (Sniderman, Hagendoorn and Prior, 2004; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Weiss and Tulin, 2021; Findor et al., 2022).

Evidence specific to naturalization is more limited but suggestive. Signals associated with integration potential increase support for granting citizenship in several European settings (Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016). Naturalization itself improves economic, political, and social integration outcomes (Hainmueller, Hangartner and Pietrantuono, 2017) and sits at the core of debates about political membership and the civic foundations of nationhood (Bloemraad, 2018; Goodman and Wright, 2020; Peters, Vink and Schmeets, 2018). Yet the conditions under which integration cues shape support for naturalization remain insufficiently understood, particularly in non-Western democracies.

Cultural distance further conditions baseline acceptance. Immigrants perceived as ethnically or religiously distant face sharper penalties (Brader, Valentino and Suhay, 2008; Ford, 2011; Choi, Poertner and Sambanis, 2022), a pattern especially salient in East Asia, where immigrants from Muslim-majority and Southeast Asian countries receive consistently lower support (Denney and Green, 2021, 2024; Rich et al., 2022; Kao and Liu, 2025). Integration cues may therefore matter most in these settings, even if they cannot fully offset strong symbolic boundaries. The question is how civic behavior interacts with contextual features of democratic systems to shape preferences over naturalization.

2.2 National Identity and Civic Legacies

One explanation highlights historically rooted civic legacies: the advocacy networks and organizational practices that emerged from earlier struggles for democratic inclusion and later came to shape immigrant incorporation. Comparative research shows that dense civil society networks and durable NGO-state

partnerships anchor pro-integration norms, framing civic participation as publicly recognizable evidence of commitment (Bloemraad, 2006; Marrow, 2005; de Graauw, 2016). Where such networks are well developed, immigrants' community engagement should be more visible and more likely to influence public evaluations. The mechanism is not limited to elite advocacy; it also conditions how ordinary citizens read behavioral signals, because organized civil society provides consistent public framing of what it means for immigrants to contribute.

In East Asia, the most systematic account of these dynamics argues that South Korea's democratization-era movements built a coordinated, state-linked incorporation regime, while Taiwan's migrant advocacy has remained decentralized and loosely coordinated (Chung, 2020, 68–75, 103–116). The civic legacy framework therefore predicts stronger responsiveness to integration cues in South Korea, where organized advocacy makes civic participation more publicly salient.

A second explanation centers on national identity regimes, which define the normative criteria for political membership (Banting et al., 2019; Hur, 2022). These regimes specify whether belonging rests primarily on ascriptive attributes or whether behavioral commitment and civic participation are accepted as legitimate bases for inclusion. In civic-territorial regimes, behavioral signals should matter more because they map directly onto widely held expectations of what constitutes a “good” member of the polity.

Every country contains mixtures of civic, voluntarist, and ethnic elements of national identity (Kunovich, 2009; Reeskens and Hooghe, 2010; Bonikowski and DiMaggio, 2016), but the balance differs across our two cases. South Korea retains a more rigid identity anchored in Korean ancestry (Shin, 2006; Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Lie, 2015; Denney and Green, 2021), with minority identities facing strong conformity pressures (Denney, Steinhardt and Bhowmick, 2026). Integration cues are therefore less likely to offset ancestry-based distinctions. Taiwan, by contrast, has undergone a civic-territorial redefinition since democratization, with democratic values and territorial allegiance displacing ethnic descent as the dominant criteria for belonging (Chu and Lin, 2001; Schubert, 2004; Kaeding, 2011; Zhong, 2016). Within these boundaries, the identity regime is more pluralistic (Denney, Steinhardt and Bhowmick, 2026), and civic behavior aligns more closely with widely accepted criteria for membership. Behavioral signals of commitment should therefore exert stronger effects in Taiwan.

2.3 Logic of Case Selection

South Korea and Taiwan form a most similar systems comparison. Both democratized in the late 1980s, following prolonged periods of authoritarian rule (Haggard and Kaufman, 1995; Rigger, 1999). Each inherited ethnicized conceptions of national identity shaped by Cold War-era nation-building (Shin, 2006; Wachman, 1994) and built strong developmental states with extensive bureaucratic capacity (Johnson, 1982; Evans, 1995). Both also remained low-immigration societies until the 1990s, as noted in Figure 1 above, when labor shortages and demographic change prompted the gradual opening of migration channels (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Lan, 2006). These shared structural features create a common backdrop for evaluating how divergent identity trajectories and civic legacies shape public responses to immigrant incorporation.

The two societies diverge in the domains highlighted by the competing theories. South Korea retains a more ascriptive conception of nationhood, but it possesses a stronger civic legacy in immigrant incorporation, rooted in labor- and rights-based mobilization. Taiwan, by contrast, underwent a civic-territorial redefinition of national identity during democratization but retains a weaker, decentralized civil society that is not particularly oriented toward migrant incorporation. These contrasts yield opposing expectations: identity regime theories predict stronger integration-cue effects in Taiwan, while civic legacy theories predict stronger effects in South Korea. The case comparison is therefore part of the research design rather than background. It helps distinguish between the competing macro-level accounts alongside the conjoint evidence. Other pairings could test the same framework. Japan, originally included in the preregistered design, would have offered an intermediate case on both dimensions; countries outside the region would test whether the pattern extends to different institutional settings. The Korea-Taiwan pairing is valuable precisely because the two theories generate opposing predictions, which is uncommon in comparative designs. Table 1 summarizes the logic of the comparison.

	Taiwan	South Korea
<i>Structural conditions</i>		
Civil society	Fragmented; weak migrant-rights focus	Dense, coordinated; strong migrant-rights focus
Identity regime	Civic-territorial redefinition; weaker ascriptive core	Strong ethno-national core; limited civic-territorial shift
<i>Competing predictions for integration cue effects</i>		
Identity regime	Stronger: civic norms align with membership criteria	Weaker: ascriptive boundaries limit cue influence
Civic legacy	Weaker: fragmented civil society limits norm diffusion	Stronger: dense advocacy networks amplify civic signals

Table 1: Contrasting theoretical expectations for Taiwan and South Korea. The top section summarizes the structural similarities and differences between the two cases along two dimensions: civil society institutions and national identity regimes. The bottom section derives competing predictions for the effect of integration cues on naturalization support. Identity regime theory predicts stronger effects in Taiwan, where civic-territorial membership criteria give behavioral commitment greater normative weight. Civic legacy theory predicts stronger effects in South Korea, where dense advocacy networks should amplify the salience of civic participation. The hypotheses section formalizes these predictions.

2.4 Hypotheses

Our theoretical framework yields three core hypotheses. The first concerns the direct effect of integration cues. The second asks whether those cues soften identity-based penalties. The third contains two competing macro-level predictions about cross-national variation, derived from work on national identity regimes and historically rooted civic legacies. Both mechanisms address how publics interpret the same behavioral information, but they locate the source of variation in different places. Civic legacies matter through the density of organizational intermediaries that promote and normalize civic participation. Identity regimes matter through the normative openness of membership boundaries. Because South Korea scores high on the former and Taiwan on the latter, the two frameworks generate opposing

expectations about where integration cues should matter most.

H₁ (Main Integration Cue Effect). *Immigrants who exhibit social integration cues will receive higher support for naturalization than otherwise identical immigrants who do not.*

Integration cues signal commitment to shared civic norms and have consistently increased support for immigrant inclusion in prior experimental research (Sniderman, Hagendoorn and Prior, 2004; Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Levy and Wright, 2020; Weiss and Tulin, 2021). We therefore expect respondents in both countries to reward these behaviors.

H₂ (Cue Mitigation of Identity-Based Penalties). *Integration cues will reduce or eliminate the penalties attached to ethnic or cultural difference.*

Ethnic and cultural distance activates negative stereotypes and threat perceptions (Kinder and Sears, 1981; Brader, Valentino and Suhay, 2008). Integration cues provide especially informative signals for immigrants who otherwise face lower baseline support due to ethnic or cultural distance. Behavioral evidence of commitment should therefore attenuate, or even eliminate, identity-based discrimination.

Our final hypothesis concerns how macro-level contexts shape cue responsiveness. Our understanding of national identity regimes and civic legacies implies competing predictions:

H_{3a} (Identity Regime Prediction). *Integration cues will have stronger positive effects in Taiwan than in South Korea.*

National identity regimes predict larger cue effects where membership boundaries are civic and flexible (Brubaker, 1992; Shulman, 2004; Verkuyten and Martinovic, 2015). As discussed above, Taiwan's post-democratization shift toward civic-territorial nationhood has elevated behavioral commitment as a key criterion for belonging (Chu and Lin, 2001; Zhong, 2016), whereas South Korea's national identity remains more ascriptive and anchored in ancestry (Shin, 2006; Hur, 2022). Integration cues should therefore be more effective in Taiwan.

H_{3b} (Civic Legacy Prediction). *Integration cues will have stronger positive effects in South Korea than in Taiwan.*

Civic legacy theories emphasize how historically rooted civil society mobilization and NGO-state coordination shape the visibility and interpretation of pro-integration norms (Marrow, 2005; Bloemraad, 2006; de Graauw, 2016; Jones-Correa, 1998). South Korea’s dense advocacy ecosystem should make civic behavior more salient, whereas Taiwan’s more fragmented civic environment should weaken this signal.

We adjudicate between H_{3a} and H_{3b} by comparing integration cue AMCEs across countries. H_{3a} is supported if cue effects are consistently and substantively larger in Taiwan; H_{3b} is supported if they are consistently larger in South Korea. If cross-national differences are small or mixed across cue types, neither prediction finds clear support. We supplement the comparison with a pooled model interacting cue levels with a country indicator (Appendix F) and with within-country mechanism tests (civic identity moderation and the civil society framing prime, Appendix D).

3 Design, Data, and Methodology

We measure native attitudes toward immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan using a choice-based conjoint experiment (Hainmueller, Hopkins and Yamamoto, 2014). Online surveys were administered through Qualtrics between January and June 2024 to native-born citizens. Respondents were recruited using stratified quota sampling to match national census distributions for age, sex, and region. Quality controls included Qualtrics’ fraud-detection tools, attention and manipulation checks, and manual verification of survey completion. Cases failing these checks were replaced in consultation with Qualtrics staff. The final samples consist of 1,999 respondents in South Korea and 2,050 in Taiwan. Appendix A provides additional detail on sampling procedures, quality checks, and respondent demographics. The study was preregistered prior to data collection (Appendix B).*

Each respondent completed a series of evaluation tasks. At the start of each task, respondents were told that the national legislature was considering a new naturalization program and that public input would help guide the policy. They then viewed two immigrant profiles and selected which applicant should be prioritized for citizenship. Respondents also rated each immigrant on a 1–7 naturalization pri-

*The preregistered design included Japan as a third case and used country of origin as the primary cultural-distance indicator. Japan was dropped due to funding constraints, and religion replaced country of origin following peer feedback. Appendix B documents these and other deviations from the preregistered plan.

ority scale. South Korean respondents completed ten paired-choice tasks; Taiwanese respondents completed seven. After the final conjoint task, respondents provided an open-ended justification of their decision.

Table 2 summarizes the twelve randomized profile attributes and levels, and Table 3 displays the interface. Three attributes correspond directly to the hypotheses: (1) a behavioral integration cue (volunteering or community participation), (2) ethnicity, and (3) religion. The remaining attributes (family status, age, sex, prior work experience, prior trips, years since arrival, and language ability) were included to enhance realism and improve identification of the core attribute effects. All profile attributes were independently randomized with equal probability. Randomization checks indicate balance across covariates and across the two national samples (Appendix C).

We selected volunteering and co-hosting multicultural events because they are the most institutionally comparable forms of civic engagement across South Korea and Taiwan. Both are common enough to be recognizable, public enough to be noticed, and generic enough to avoid country-specific political meaning. Volunteering captures direct engagement with local institutions. Co-hosting events captures visible participation in community life and carries a modest pluralist signal. Together, they provide behavioral cues that respondents in both settings can interpret in similar ways.

The experimental design has two layers of random assignment. All profile attributes vary at the task level, which identifies the causal effects of specific immigrant traits. The behavioral integration cue, our primary treatment, varies at the respondent level. Following best practices (Kirkland and Coppock, 2018), respondent-level assignment avoids within-task interference, cue dilution, and learning effects. Respondents either saw profiles that included the integration cue (e.g., “volunteers weekly,” “co-hosts civic events”) in every task or saw profiles with no such behavioral information. That structure lets us estimate how exposure to integration cues shapes evaluations across the full set of conjoint tasks, independent of attribute ordering or task sequencing. The H_1 AMCEs are estimated from the cue-shown subsample only; the H_2 subgroup analyses use the full sample by comparing cue-shown and cue-not-shown conditions.

A civil society framing message was also randomized at the respondent level. Half of the respondents

received a short introductory statement emphasizing the role of NGOs, community groups, and local organizations in immigration policymaking (see Appendix D for the full prompt and exploratory results). This is an auxiliary within-case probe, not the core civic legacy test. The main test of the civic legacy argument still comes from the case comparison itself: South Korea pairs denser migrant advocacy with more ascriptive boundaries, while Taiwan pairs weaker migrant advocacy with a more civic-territorial conception of membership.

The design supports direct tests of the three hypotheses described above. All estimates come from ordinary least squares (OLS) linear probability models with standard errors clustered by respondent (Hainmueller, Hopkins and Yamamoto, 2014). We report both AMCEs and marginal means. AMCEs estimate the causal effect of attribute levels relative to a reference category and should be read as average preferences across the attribute distribution, not as preferences for specific profiles (Abramson, Kocak and Magazinnik, 2022). For the integration cue, the reference is “spends time alone”; for ethnicity, the reference is co-ethnic; for religion, the reference is not religious. Conjoint designs also mitigate social desirability bias by embedding sensitive attributes within multidimensional profiles, which lowers the salience of any single dimension (Horiuchi, Markovich and Yamamoto, 2022). For H_1 , we estimate the main effect of integration cues using average marginal component effects (AMCEs) and marginal means. For H_2 , the main figures pair subgroup marginal means with cue-specific cross-national contrasts, so the reader can see both absolute support levels and the formal Taiwan-versus-South Korea difference in cue premiums relative to the baseline of spending time alone (Leeper, Hobolt and Tilley, 2020). For H_{3a} and H_{3b} , we compare integration cue effects across Taiwan and South Korea to see which macro-level expectation better matches the observed pattern. Two further tests supplement the cross-national comparison.

First, we assess whether civic nationalists within each country exhibit stronger sensitivity to integration cues, which would be most consistent with the identity regime expectation. Civic nationalists define national membership through shared values, democratic commitment, and civic participation (Sniderman, Hagendoorn and Prior, 2004; Kunovich, 2009; Bonikowski and DiMaggio, 2016), and should therefore place greater weight on behavioral evidence of commitment. If the identity regime mechanism is correct, we should observe the strongest responsiveness among Taiwanese civic nationalists, whose

country's civic-territorial identity shift has elevated behavioral commitment as a key criterion for membership, unlike in South Korea, where ancestry remains more salient. Respondents' national identity orientations are measured using standard survey items (Kunovich, 2009; Bonikowski and DiMaggio, 2016). We classify respondents as civic identifiers if they assign importance to legal citizenship and institutional respect but do not simultaneously assign importance to both ancestry and birthplace; all others are coded as non-civic identifiers. Appendix D reports the full coding rule and the alternative Taiwan specification.

Second, we evaluate whether the civil society framing message amplifies cue responsiveness. This test follows from the civic legacy expectation, which links public interpretations of immigrant behavior to historically rooted patterns of civil society mobilization and coordination with the state. In South Korea, these networks are dense, institutionalized, and closely integrated into local governance, so highlighting civil society involvement in immigration policy should make civic engagement by immigrants more salient. Taiwan's civil society institutions, by contrast, are less developed and more fragmented, and civil society organizations play a more limited and uneven role in immigrant incorporation. If civic legacies shape how behavioral information is interpreted, the framing prime should therefore increase responsiveness to integration cues in South Korea but not in Taiwan.

Attribute	Levels
<i>Social integration</i>	Associates only with expatriates; Spends time alone; Co-hosts multicultural events; Volunteers weekly at a community center
<i>Ethnicity</i>	Co-ethnic; Not co-ethnic
<i>Religion</i>	Not religious; Christian; Buddhist; Muslim
Country of origin	United States; China; Indonesia; Brazil ^a ; South Korea ^b ; the Philippines
Occupation	Programmer/engineer; Farmer/agricultural worker; Unemployed; Office worker
Family status	Single; Married; Married with children
Age	27; 36 ^a / 35 ^b ; 47; 58
Sex	Male; Female
Prior work experience	None; Worked in home country; Worked previously in country
Prior trips	Visited once with friends; Previously overstayed visa; Short-term working visa
Years since arrival	2; 7; 12 ^a / 5; 8; 12 ^b
Language ability	None; A little; Conversational; Fluent ^a / Broken; Conversational; Fluent ^b

^aSouth Korea only. ^bTaiwan only.

Table 2: Conjoint experiment attributes and levels. Attributes in *italics* denote the primary quantities of interest.

	Immigrant A	Immigrant B
Social integration	Only associates with fellow expatriates	Co-hosts multicultural events
Religion	Christian	Muslim
Ethnicity	Co-ethnic	Non-co-ethnic
Country of origin	United States	Indonesia
Occupation	Unemployed	Agricultural worker
Age	36	47
Sex	Male	Female
Family status	Single	Married with children
Prior work experience	None	Worked previously in the country
Prior trips to the country	Has previously overstayed a visa	Visited on a short-term working visa
Years since arrival	7 years	2 years
Native language ability	Fluent	Conversational
Please choose which immigrant you prefer for citizenship.		
	☐ Immigrant A	☐ Immigrant B
Rate each immigrant's citizenship priority: 1 (not at all) to 7 (definitely).		
Immigrant A:	1	2 3 4 5 6 7
Immigrant B:	1	2 3 4 5 6 7

Table 3: The experimental design. English-language approximation of the conjoint interface. Respondents chose which immigrant to prioritize for citizenship and rated each on a 1–7 scale.

Three design issues matter for interpretation. First, conjoint responses are subject to measurement error from profile swapping, in which respondents reverse their intended selection (Clayton et al., 2023). In comparable paired-profile designs, individual repeatability rates average roughly 75 percent. This attenuation bias pushes AMCEs toward zero and marginal means toward 0.5, so the effects we report should be interpreted as lower-bound estimates. Following Clayton et al., we apply a conservative intra-respondent reliability (IRR) benchmark of 0.75 and report corrected estimates in Appendix F. For subgroup comparisons, the direction of bias is less predictable, and we therefore focus on substantive patterns rather than individual point estimates. Second, with twelve profile attributes and multiple subgroup contrasts, there

are many implicit comparisons. We address this by concentrating on theoretically motivated hypotheses and interpreting patterns across tests rather than isolated significance results (Liu and Shiraito, 2023). We also apply Benjamini-Hochberg false discovery rate correction to all hypothesis tests; results are reported in Appendix F and no substantive conclusions change. Third, the effective sample sizes for this study are $1,999 \times 10 = 19,990$ paired-choice tasks for South Korea and $2,050 \times 7 = 14,350$ for Taiwan, yielding 39,980 and 28,700 profile-level observations, respectively. South Korean respondents evaluated ten paired-choice tasks and Taiwanese respondents evaluated seven. The difference reflects pilot testing: Taiwan’s instrument included additional open-text items that increased completion time, so tasks were reduced to maintain data quality and minimize attrition (Bansak et al., 2021). With over 14,000 profile evaluations per country, even the smaller Taiwanese sample provides adequate statistical power to detect AMCEs of 2–3 percentage points at conventional significance levels (Stefanelli and Lukac, 2024). Task-order stability analysis (Appendix F) shows no systematic differences between early and late conjoint tasks.

4 Findings

This section presents the results of the conjoint experiments in South Korea and Taiwan, organized around the three hypotheses developed above. Full model specifications and robustness checks using ratings outcomes are presented in Appendix D.

4.1 Main Effects of Integration Cues

Across both countries, cues of civic engagement increase support for naturalization. Figure 2 reports marginal means and AMCEs. The integration attribute ranges from prosocial civic engagement (volunteering, co-hosting events) to social withdrawal or separation (spending time alone, interacting only with foreigners). The estimates therefore capture both the premium for civic engagement and the penalty for visible non-integration. Respondents treat spending most of one’s time alone and interacting only with other foreign residents almost the same. In South Korea, the marginal means for those two conditions

are about 42 percent and 43 percent. In Taiwan, they are about 40 percent and 41 percent.

The positive cues move opinion in both countries. In South Korea, volunteering weekly at a community center raises support by 16 percentage points relative to spending time alone. Co-hosting multicultural events raises it by 13 points. In Taiwan, the gains are larger: 21 points for volunteering and 17 for co-hosting. Volunteering produces the stronger response in both cases. That makes sense given the attribute design. Community centers signal direct engagement with host-society institutions, while multicultural events can also involve participation with other foreign residents and therefore send a weaker signal of host-society integration.

Relative to the baseline of spending time alone, the volunteering effect is about 5 percentage points larger in Taiwan than in South Korea, and the co-hosting effect is about 4 points larger. Respondents in Taiwan put more weight on these behavioral cues when they judge naturalization claims. Visible civic engagement earns a clear premium in both countries (H_1). The rating outcome in Appendix D shows the same pattern. Open-ended justifications collected after each respondent's final conjoint task ($N=4,047$) corroborate the finding: structural topic models and LLM-based classification both show that cue-exposed respondents shift toward language of civic commitment and community participation, with larger shifts in Taiwan (Appendix E).

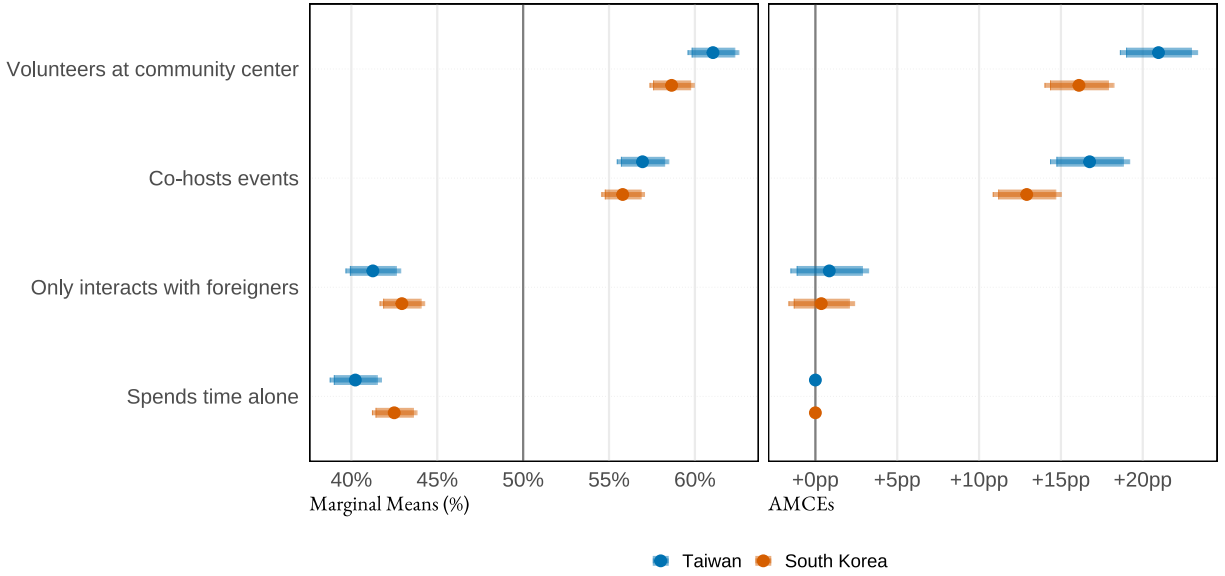


Figure 2: Marginal means and AMCEs for the effect of the integration cue attribute. The analysis is based on an Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) model with clustered standard errors. Marginal means represent the expected value of the outcome variable for each attribute level, holding all other attributes at their average levels. The AMCEs estimate the average change in the outcome variable associated with a particular attribute level, relative to a reference level, averaged across the distribution of all other attributes. Error bars represent 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals (thicker bars = 90%, thinner bars = 95%).

4.2 Integration Cues and Identity-Based Discrimination

We next examine whether integration cues mitigate baseline penalties associated with ethnic and religious differences, which we consider ascriptive and cultural identity markers, respectively. Because the subgroup question concerns both cue responsiveness and overall profile favorability, Figures 3 and 4 use a hybrid presentation (Leeper, Hobolt and Tilley, 2020). The top panels report subgroup marginal means for South Korea and Taiwan, which makes it easy to see whether a profile rises above the 50 percent acceptance threshold in the forced-choice task. The bottom panels report the formal Taiwan-minus-South Korea difference in each positive cue premium relative to the baseline of spending time alone.

Regarding ethnicity, Figure 3 shows the same broad pattern in both countries: positive cues lift support for both ethnic groups, but they do more to narrow the baseline penalty for non-co-ethnic applicants. In South Korea, co-ethnic profiles rise from about 46 percent when the immigrant spends time alone to 60–61 percent under the two positive cues, while non-co-ethnic profiles rise from about 39 per-

cent to 52–56 percent. In Taiwan, the same baseline for non-co-ethnic applicants rises from about 39 percent to 55 percent under co-hosting and 60 percent under volunteering, which brings those profiles much closer to co-ethnic ones. The bottom panels show that Taiwan’s cue premium is somewhat larger than South Korea’s for both ethnic groups, on the order of about 3 to 5 percentage points, but the cross-national difference remains modest.

Religious identity produces larger baseline penalties, particularly for Muslim applicants. Figure 4 makes that clearer than the effect plots alone. In South Korea, Muslim profiles start at about 36 percent when the immigrant spends time alone and rise only to about 45 percent under co-hosting and 47 percent under volunteering, still below the 50 percent threshold. In Taiwan, Muslim profiles begin at about 34 percent but rise to 54 percent under co-hosting and 58 percent under volunteering. The bottom panels show that this is also where the formal cross-national difference is concentrated: Taiwan’s cue premium for Muslim profiles is about 11 percentage points larger under co-hosting and about 13 points larger under volunteering. Positive cues also move Christian, unaffiliated, and Buddhist/other profiles upward in both countries, but those cross-national differences are much smaller.

That comparison points to the same conclusion as the interaction estimates. Behavioral commitment matters in both countries, but it does more to overcome cultural distance in Taiwan than in South Korea. For religious difference especially, the combined marginal-means and country-difference presentation shows not just larger cue effects in Taiwan, but a substantively different outcome: positive cues move Muslim profiles above majority support in Taiwan but not in South Korea.

Integration cues reduce identity-based penalties, but the size of that reduction varies by context and by group (H_2). In Taiwan, integration cues narrow identity-based gaps most sharply for the most culturally distant groups. In South Korea, the same cues help, but less, and they help Muslim immigrants least. Behavioral evidence of commitment matters in both contexts, but it does not erase the social weight carried by ethnic and religious distance.

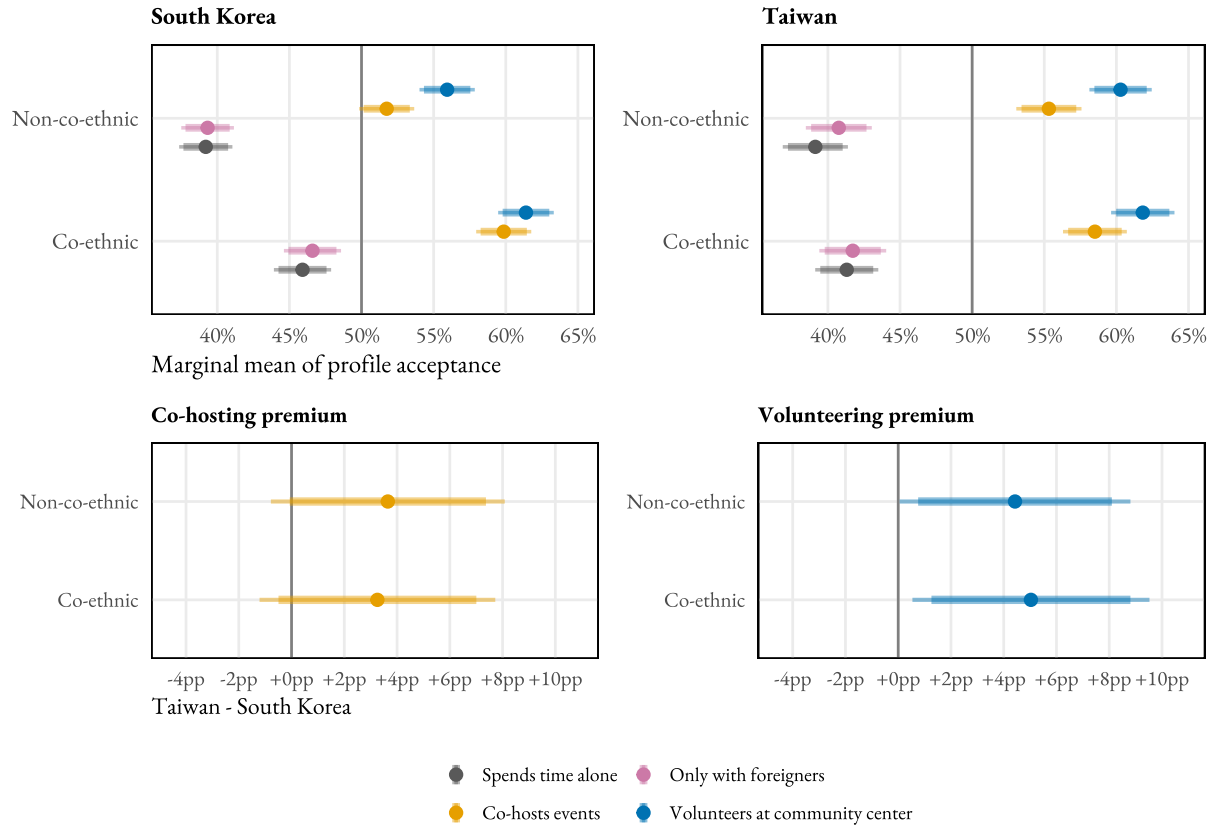


Figure 3: Ethnicity and integration cues: subgroup marginal means and cross-national cue-premium differences. The top panels report the probability that a co-ethnic or non-co-ethnic profile is selected in the forced-choice task under four cue conditions, shown separately for South Korea and Taiwan. Here, co-ethnic denotes ethnic Korean profiles in South Korea and Han profiles in Taiwan. The bottom panels report the Taiwan-minus-South Korea difference in the co-hosting and volunteering premiums, each relative to the baseline of spending time alone. In the top panels, the vertical line marks 50 percent support; in the bottom panels, it marks zero cross-national difference. Error bars represent 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals (thicker bars = 90%, thinner bars = 95%).

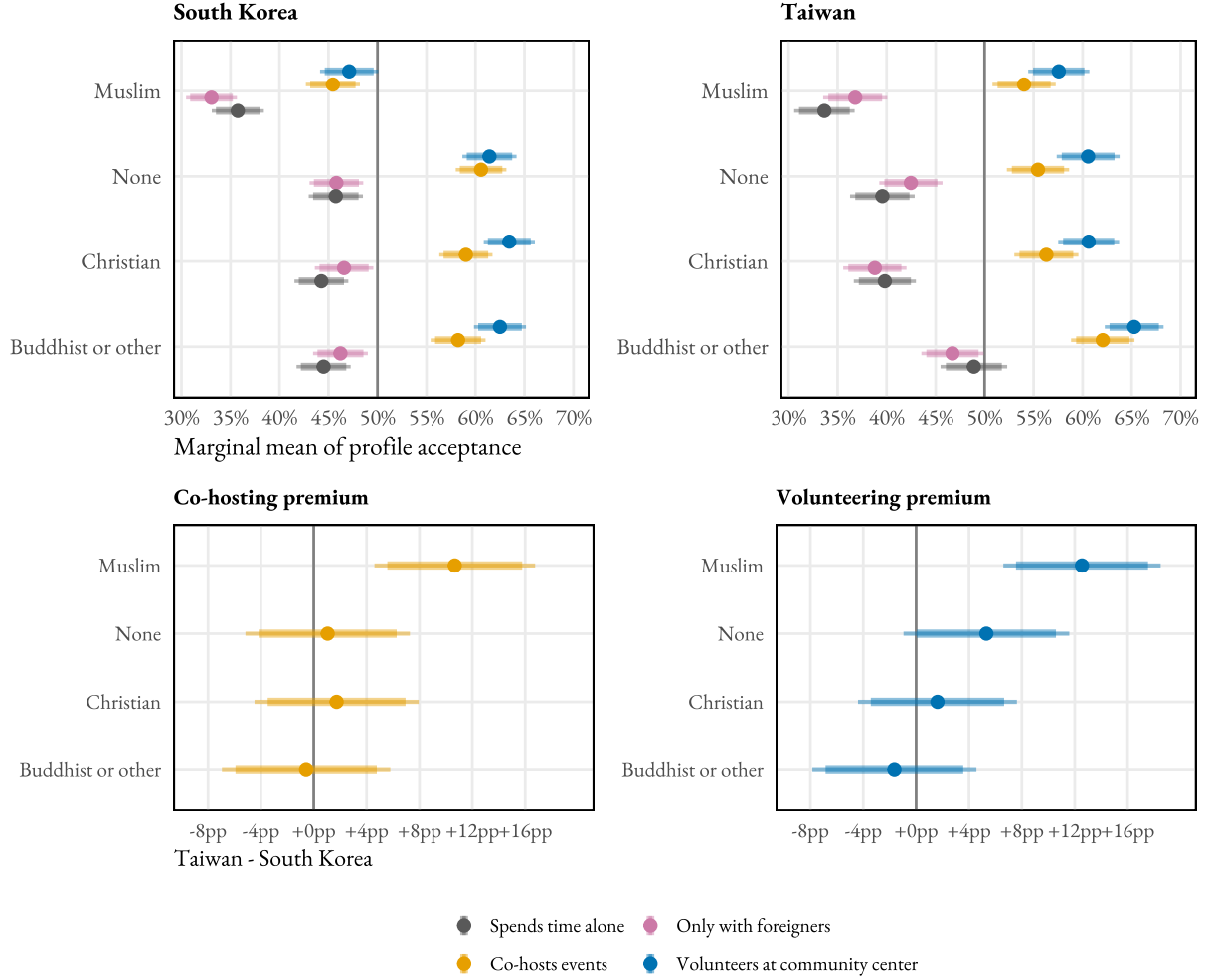


Figure 4: Religion and integration cues: subgroup marginal means and cross-national cue-premium differences. The top panels report the probability that a profile is selected in the forced-choice task for each religious category under four cue conditions, shown separately for South Korea and Taiwan. The bottom panels report the Taiwan-minus-South Korea difference in the co-hosting and volunteering premiums, each relative to the baseline of spending time alone. In the top panels, the vertical line marks 50 percent support; in the bottom panels, it marks zero cross-national difference. Error bars represent 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals (thicker bars = 90%, thinner bars = 95%).

4.3 Cross-National Patterns and Mechanism Tests

The cross-national pattern is more consistent with the identity regime prediction than the civic legacy prediction (H_{3a} over H_{3b}). Across the positive cue conditions, effects are larger in Taiwan than in South Korea. The pooled model with country interactions (Appendix F, Table F.3) confirms that the volun-

teering and co-hosting effects are about four to five percentage points larger in Taiwan. The subgroup analyses sharpen the contrast. For ethnicity, Taiwan's edge is modest. For religion, it is largest among Muslim applicants, who also face the steepest baseline penalty. If behavioral commitment carries more weight where membership is defined in more civic terms, this is the pattern we would expect. Appendix E serves a narrower purpose. It shows that respondents used cue-relevant themes in their justifications, but it does not sort between the two macro accounts.

Two additional tests point in the same direction, though weakly (detailed results appear in Appendix D). First, civic nationalists respond more positively to integration cues in Taiwan than in South Korea, but the difference shows up mainly for volunteering rather than across all positive behaviors. In South Korea, the corresponding gaps are small and imprecise. This is, at most, weak additional support for the identity regime account (H_{3a}). Second, the civil society framing message does not increase cue responsiveness in South Korea, where the civic legacy account would expect the largest effect.

5 Discussion and Conclusion

This paper examines how behavioral integration cues shape public support for immigrant naturalization in Taiwan and South Korea. Using nationally representative conjoint experiments, we ask how citizens interpret immigrant civic engagement and when those behaviors affect naturalization preferences.

The main finding is straightforward. In both Taiwan and South Korea, cues of civic participation increase support for naturalization by roughly 13 to 21 percentage points relative to a baseline of no engagement. That result fits earlier work showing that integration cues operate as signals of norm conformity and commitment (Levy and Wright, 2020; Weiss and Tulin, 2021). Here, the same logic extends to citizenship, where judgments about immigrants bear directly on political membership (Bloemraad, 2018; Goodman and Wright, 2020). Even in settings with strong ethno-national traditions, civic engagement remains a recognizable sign that an immigrant has taken on obligations associated with belonging.

The penalty-reduction findings are less even across groups and countries. In Taiwan, civic participation narrows gaps between majority and minority groups, with the largest gains among Muslim ap-

plicants, who begin from the lowest baseline. In South Korea, the same cues help, but they help less. Muslim immigrant profiles benefit the least: even under the strongest positive cue, Muslim profiles in South Korea do not cross the 50 percent support threshold. That pattern is striking because it persists despite South Korea's dense migrant advocacy infrastructure, which actively promotes inclusion. It suggests that civic behavior cannot fully offset ascriptive boundaries when those boundaries are reinforced by a national identity regime that treats ancestry as central to belonging (Seol and Skrentny, 2009; Shin, 2006). South Korea's small Muslim population and limited institutional familiarity with Islam as a lived religion may compound the penalty, as anti-Muslim sentiment in Korean public discourse has grown alongside online mobilization and media framing that associates Islam with cultural threat (Denney and Green, 2021). The divergence also echoes findings from Western Europe, where Muslim immigrants face steeper penalties than other culturally distant groups even when they demonstrate civic commitment (Adida, Laitin and Valfort, 2016; Findor et al., 2022).

The cross-national comparison fits the identity regime argument better than the civic legacy argument. Integration cues matter more in Taiwan, which is what we would expect if civic-territorial membership criteria make behavioral commitment more relevant to judgments about belonging (Brubaker, 1992; Shulman, 2004; Verkuyten and Martinovic, 2015). The mechanism is not simply that Taiwanese respondents are more tolerant in general. Rather, Taiwan's post-democratization shift toward civic-territorial nationhood has redefined the criteria against which immigrant behavior is evaluated (Chu and Lin, 2001; Zhong, 2016). This shift is not merely abstract: competing parties claim ownership of Taiwanese identity across ethnic lines, and non-Han histories have entered school curricula and public narratives (Chen, Lin and Yang, 2023), creating a context in which behavioral commitment is recognizable as a membership criterion. When membership rests on values and participation rather than ancestry, behavioral signals become legible as evidence of qualification. That is why cue effects are not only larger in Taiwan but also do more to offset identity-based penalties: the same act of volunteering carries different informational weight depending on the evaluative framework within which it is interpreted. South Korea's denser and historically rooted civic institutions, which should make civic participation more visible if the civic legacy story were driving public opinion (Marrow, 2005; Bloemraad, 2006; Chung, 2020), do

not produce larger cue effects here. In this comparison, civic legacies still matter for advocacy fields and state-society coordination, but they appear to matter less than identity regimes for how ordinary citizens read behavioral signals. The point is not that civic legacies are irrelevant. It is that, in these two cases, membership boundaries do more to shape mass responses to integration cues.

These results add to three debates. First, they shift attention from admission and residence preferences (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak, Hainmueller and Hangartner, 2016; Weber et al., 2025) to naturalization, where public judgments help determine who receives political membership (Bloemraad, 2018; Peters, Vink and Schmeets, 2018). Second, they show that national identity regimes matter not only because individuals hold civic or ethnic views, but also because those regimes shape how the same behavioral signal is interpreted at the mass level. The Korea-Taiwan comparison shows that identical acts of civic engagement can carry different weight depending on whether behavioral commitment is treated as a legitimate basis for belonging. Third, they qualify arguments about meso-level institutions and mass opinion. South Korea and Taiwan separate organized migrant advocacy from membership boundaries in a way that makes the two accounts pull in opposite directions, and the comparison suggests that identity regimes do more than civic legacies to shape how citizens read evidence of commitment.

Civic engagement can increase support for naturalization, but its effect depends on how it fits prevailing conceptions of belonging. Integration cues reduce identity-based barriers without eliminating them. Policies that facilitate immigrant participation in community institutions may therefore increase support for naturalization, but their effects will vary across societies depending on whether behavioral commitment fits widely accepted membership criteria.

The design also has limits. First, the macro-level argument rests on a two-country comparison, so the paper cannot cleanly separate identity regimes from civic legacies. More cases, especially ones that combine strong civic legacies with civic-territorial identity regimes, would help sort the two mechanisms more convincingly. Second, conjoint profiles are stylized. They improve internal validity and blunt some social desirability concerns (Horiuchi, Markovich and Yamamoto, 2022), but they do not reproduce real encounters with immigrants. The integration cue attribute also bundles reward for civic engagement with penalty for visible non-integration, since it spans behaviors from volunteering to social withdrawal (de la

Cuesta, Egami and Imai, 2022). Third, the two-country comparison cannot fully rule out confounds beyond the focal theories. Differences in immigration discourse salience, media environment, or survey context may contribute to the Korea-Taiwan gap. The within-country randomization and standardized conjoint structure mitigate the most serious threats by isolating attribute effects from country-level baselines, but they cannot eliminate all unobserved heterogeneity between national contexts.

With those limits in mind, the Korea-Taiwan comparison still shows that integration cues are not uniform signals. Their meaning depends on the identity regimes within which they are interpreted. Democracies that have undergone civic-territorial redefinitions of nationhood may be more receptive to behavioral evidence of commitment, while those that retain stronger ascriptive boundaries may continue to discount such evidence, especially for culturally distant groups.

These findings also raise questions that reach beyond the two cases studied here. If identity regimes shape how publics interpret immigrant behavior, then changes to those regimes should shift the returns to civic engagement over time. Taiwan's identity regime has moved toward civic-territorial criteria over the past three decades; South Korea's has been slower to change. Whether integration cues become more effective in South Korea as its identity regime evolves, or whether ascriptive boundaries prove durable even under institutional pressure, is a question that longitudinal and multi-country designs are better positioned to answer. These findings speak most directly to recently democratized societies where immigration is a relatively new phenomenon and where identity regimes and civic legacies can be observed in divergent configurations. Extending the comparison to other emerging immigrant-receiving democracies, including cases where civic legacies and identity regimes do not pull in opposite directions, would clarify how far the identity regime account generalizes.

Preregistration

This study was preregistered on the Open Science Framework prior to data collection (<https://osf.io/xfcuy>; September 25, 2023). Deviations from the preregistered design are documented in the Supplementary Information.

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Ethics Statement

This research was conducted in accordance with ethical guidelines approved by the University of Vienna Ethics Committee under decision numbers 00654 and 00997. Respondents completed the survey through Qualtrics after reviewing the study information and consent language in the instrument.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Replication materials for the quantitative analyses, including the scripts, processed data, and figure-generation files used in the paper, are archived in a project repository that will be made publicly available upon publication. Requests for data and/or scripts will be considered by the authors.

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